

From Prompt to Pipeline

Transforming Workflows with Custom AI Skills

Hands-On Lab Guide

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1. Objective

By the end of this lab, you will be able to:

- Understand what an AI Skill is and how it extends GitHub Copilot.
- Set up your local development environment with VS Code and the required extensions.
- Create and configure a SKILL.md file that drives browser automation.
- Deploy the `quicker-csone-sr-dump` skill to automate SR data extraction from Cisco CSOne.

2. What is an AI Skill?

An AI Skill is a modular, reusable unit of automation that extends the capabilities of an AI assistant like GitHub Copilot. It acts as a bridge between a natural language prompt and technical execution — whether that means interacting with a browser-based tool, querying a database, or automating a multi-step workflow.

At its core, a Skill is defined by a single Markdown file (SKILL.md) that instructs the AI on three things:

Concept	Description
What it does	The purpose of the skill — summarised for the AI.
When to trigger	The specific natural language phrases that activate it.
How to act	The step-by-step logic or browser automation the AI will execute.

3. Environment Setup

Complete the steps below before building your skill. Each sub-section must be finished in order.

3.1 Install & Configure VS Code

Step 1

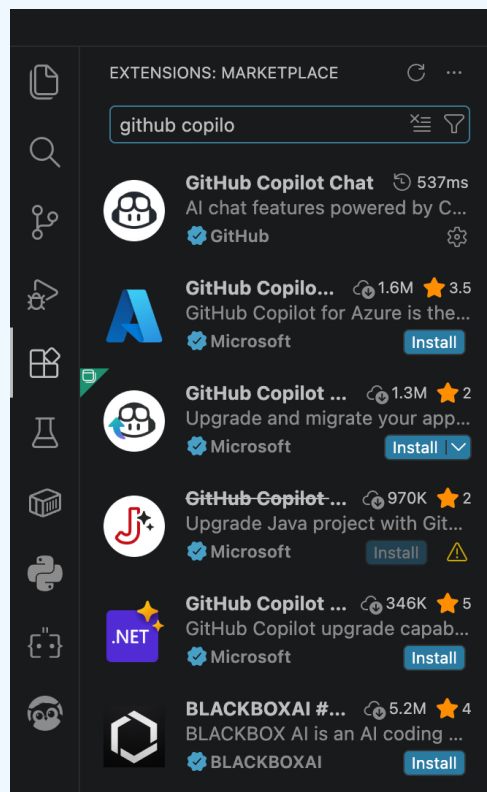
Download VS Code

Visit code.visualstudio.com and download the installer for your OS. Run the installer with default settings.

Step 2

Install GitHub Copilot Extensions

Open VS Code. Press **Ctrl+Shift+X** to open the Extensions panel. Search for **GitHub Copilot** and **GitHub Copilot Chat**, then click Install on both.



Step 3

Sign In to Copilot

Click the Copilot icon in the bottom-right status bar. Select **Sign In** → **Continue with GitHub**. Authenticate using your CEC ID via DUO SSO when prompted.

Step 4**Verify Account Access**

Ensure your `<cecID>_cisco` account is authorized for Copilot. Go to [GitHub Copilot Settings](#) and confirm that Copilot is enabled for your account.

Note

If Copilot does not activate after sign-in, confirm your account has an active Cisco Copilot seat assigned. Reach out to your team lead if access is missing.

4. The SKILL.md Framework

Every AI Skill is powered by a single file: SKILL.md. Think of it as an instruction sheet the AI reads before acting. It tells Copilot exactly what the skill is for, how to recognize when to use it, and what steps to take.

4.1 Key Sections of a SKILL.md

Section	Purpose
name	A unique identifier for the skill.
description	A short summary of what the skill does and when to use it.
triggers	Phrases that will activate the skill (e.g. "dump SR", "get SR notes").
steps	The ordered automation steps the AI will follow when triggered.

Full reference: [Skills Getting Started Guide](#)

5. Lab Exercise: Implementing quicker-csone-sr-dump

In this exercise you will configure and deploy the `quicker-csone-sr-dump` skill, which automates SR data extraction from Cisco CSOne. Follow each step in order.

Step A — Configure the Skill

1. Create a new folder on your machine for this project (e.g).

```
mkdir ~/ai-skills-lab && cd ~/ai-skills-lab
```

2. Open the [Skills Repository](#) and copy the SKILL.md template into your project folder.
3. Review the trigger phrases defined at the top of the file. The default triggers are:

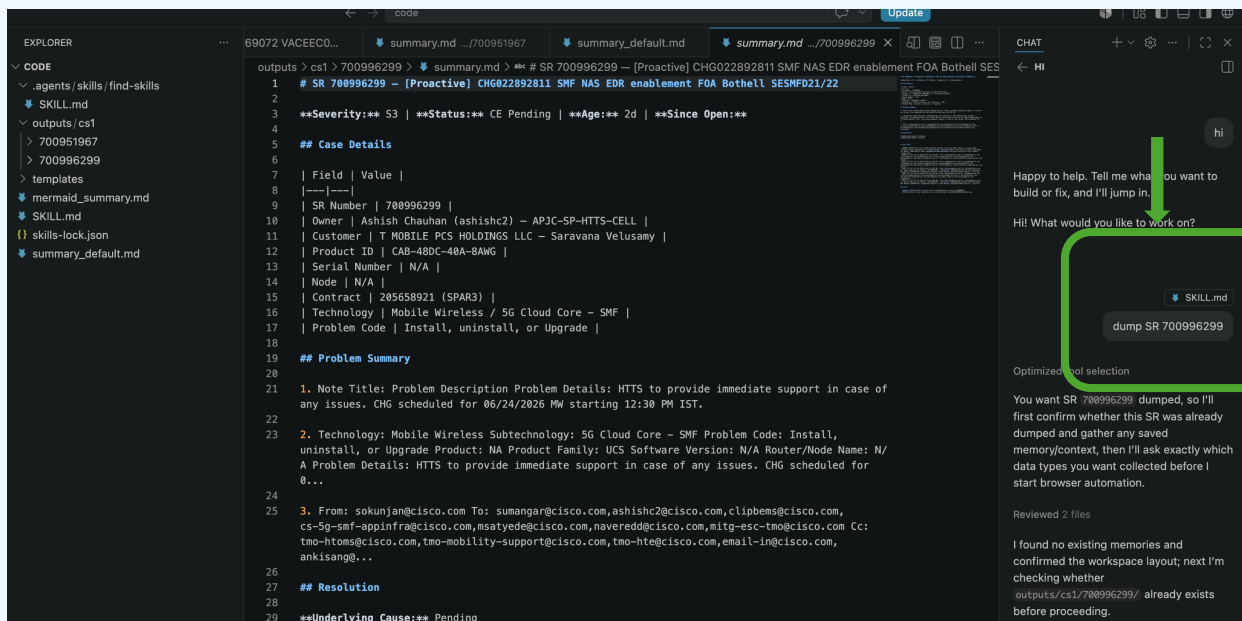
```
triggers:  
- "download SR"  
- "dump SR"  
- "get SR notes"
```

Tip

You can add your own trigger phrases to the list. Keep them short, natural, and distinct from other skills to avoid accidental activation.

Step B — Integration & Testing

4. **Open Copilot Chat.** In VS Code, press **Ctrl+Alt+I** to open the Copilot Chat panel.
5. **Attach the SKILL.md file.** Click the **+ Attach context** button at the top of the Chat panel, then select your **SKILL.md** file. This tells Copilot which skill to load.



6. **Approve permissions.** The first time you run a skill, Copilot will request permission to execute browser automation. Review the prompt carefully and click **Allow**.

7. **Run a test prompt.** Type one of the following in the chat window and press Enter:

Get the details for SR 699728707

— or —

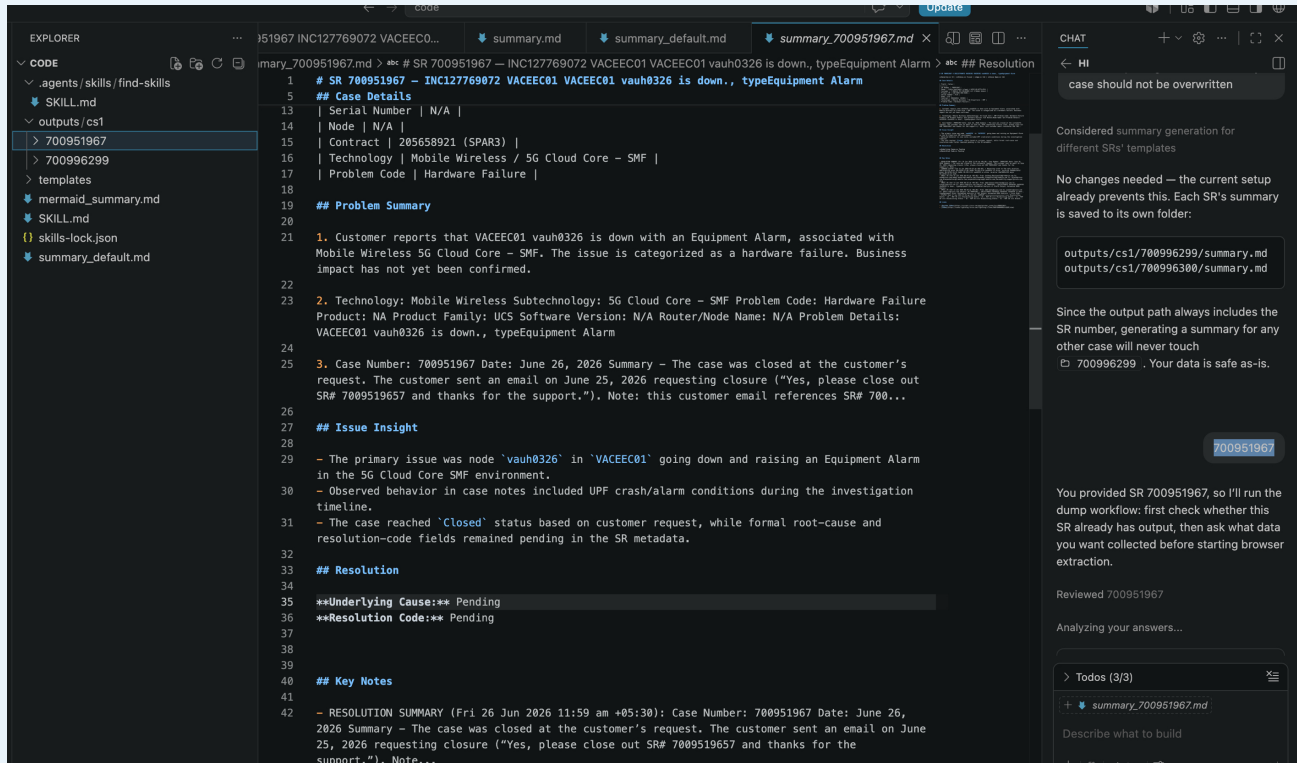
dump SR

8. **Observe the output.** Watch as Copilot parses your prompt, triggers the browser automation, navigates to CSOne, and retrieves the SR data. The results will appear directly in the chat window.

Expected Outcome

The SR record details — including case notes, status, and owner — should appear in the Copilot Chat window within a few seconds.

If nothing happens, verify that the SKILL.md file is attached and that browser automation permissions were granted.



6. Troubleshooting

Issue	Resolution
Copilot icon not appearing in VS Code	Ensure both GitHub Copilot and GitHub Copilot Chat extensions are installed and VS Code has been restarted.
Sign-in fails / DUO prompt not shown	Check your network connection and confirm your CEC ID is active. Try signing in via a browser first.
Skill does not trigger	Confirm SKILL.md is attached in the Chat panel. Verify the phrase you typed matches one of the defined triggers.
Browser automation permission denied	Re-open the Copilot Chat and re-attach SKILL.md. The permission prompt will reappear on the next skill execution.
SR data not returned	Confirm you are logged in to CSOne in your browser. Browser automation requires an active CSOne session.

7. Resources & Documentation

- [AI for Everything — Skills README](#)
- [Skill Development Best Practices](#)
- [quicker-csone-sr-dump SKILL.md Template](#)
- [GitHub Copilot Settings](#)

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